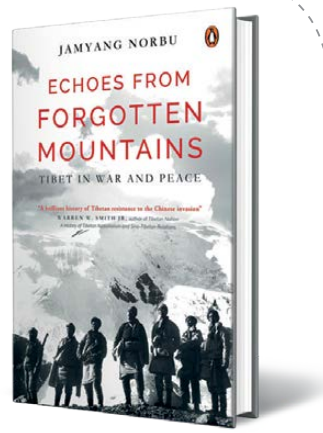
BOOKS

CHRONICLING TIBET

By Bérénice Guyot-Réchard

From Ukraine and Armenia to Israel-Palestine, 2023 has reminded us that many people across the world still fight for their freedom, more or less seen, more or less supported. Among them is the 75-year-old struggle of Tibetans against the People's Republic of China. With *Echoes of Forgotten Mountains*, Jamyang Norbu—a Kalimpong-born Tibetan who joined the resistance in the 1970s before becoming a prominent independence activist, critical of a government-in-exile he accuses of meekness towards China—offers a magnificent history of Tibetans' resistance against Chinese occupation, despite overwhelming odds, fickle American support, and the world's indifference. Others have told the story of this fight for survival. Few have told it with such power and insight. Ever since he began writing historical plays for the Tibetan Institute of Performing Arts in the '70s, Norbu realised that to document Tibetan history and culture was to resist against its erasure. Over the years, he became one of the sharpest chroniclers of his people, doggedly tracking archival material and persuading Tibetans to tell their stories.

The result is a book that is epic and intimate; deeply researched, yet passionately argued; informative, but simultaneously moving and inspiring; 962 pages long, but impossible to put down. Norbu takes us on a journey through time and space, conjuring up the lush forests of Markham, Lhasa's bustling Banakshöl neighbourhood, the meadows of Lithang, the besieged fortress of Tsethang, the mountain holdout of Mustang. In these places, countless Tibetans (rich and poor, monks and lay people, devout Buddhists and devoted sceptics, oracles and intellectuals, men and women, children and elderly, aristocrats and commoners, Lhasa urbanites and steppe nomads) lived, fought, died, and hoped. Norbu tells us of Yunru Pön, the unassuming tribal chief who led the 1955 Lithang Uprising, among the first sparks in a rebellion that would shake eastern Tibet before spreading to Lhasa; of Phagpa, the Lord Chamberlain who, Norbu suspects, masterminded the Dalai Lama's escape from Lhasa in 1959; of Chushi Gangdruk's death-defying "long ride north" through the desolate Chantang plateau, the PLA hot on their heels, a mirror image of Mao's long march; of Trinlay Chödön, the nun who, thrown out of her monastery by the Red Guards, became Nyemo Achi, the leader of the Rebel Army of the Gods, as Tibet buckled under the Cultural Revolution.



ECHOES FROM FORGOTTEN MOUNTAINS
Tibet in War and Peace
by Jamyang Norbu
Penguin Viking
₹1,299; 962 pages

Echoes... carries the sound of two hearts in particular: Bhusang, "the man whose luck dried up", and Norbu himself. The first was born to a peasant family chafing under aristocratic overlords; the second, to one such aristocratic clan forced into semi-exile in India long before Chinese annexation. Bhusang, a rookie doctor in Lhasa when it rebelled against Chinese rule in 1959, joined the desperate fight for the city, later joining CIA-trained operatives sent to Tibet to help the resistance. India-raised Norbu grew up amidst the echoes of these increasingly doomed struggles, opting to join what remained of it in northern Nepal, before going to France to see if Paris's support of Tibet would be more tangible than Washington's. Both men saw their dreams turn to dust. Captured by the PLA, Bhusang spent years in Chinese prisons and labour camps, finding, upon release, that his wife had remarried, and his children had starved to death. He left the country he had fought for, and where nothing was left for him. Norbu, after the resistance's demise, turned to writing and activism.

With these myriad entwined stories, Norbu recreates the Tibetan world in all its complexity, richness and defiance. His eyes see through its failings and failures, starting with the Dalai Lama's. Chinese, Indian and westerners alike tend to treat Tibet as a land beyond time, too antique, exotic, spiritual or isolated to survive modernity. Norbu rejects such a prism, wielding his erudition to replace Tibetan cultural practices, recourse to violence and beliefs in their global context. Meanwhile, the compassionate distance Bhusang and many interviewees display towards Buddhism subtly undoes attempts to reduce Tibetans' resistance to a primordial, atavistic and blind faith.

Today, China seems more powerful and more intent on brutally assimilating its minorities than ever. Norbu has given us a book that is elegiac and defiant in the face of this ongoing tragedy. *Echoes* is a historical work, but it is also a reminder to us, readers, that we have a responsibility to preserve that history from erasure. ■

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